BUSINESS AI STACK · CHAPTER 27

WhatsApp Business Platform

A practical guide with steps, examples and a checklist. Read the chapter, then build the example.

CHAPTER 27 · BUSINESS AI STACK

WhatsApp Business Platform: customer messaging

WhatsApp is where many customers already talk. The WhatsApp Business Platform lets your systems send and receive messages automatically, with your own number and business name.

Key concepts

- **WhatsApp Business account and phone number.** The number your customers message. It is registered through Meta Business Suite.
- **Customer service window.** After a customer messages you, you can reply with free-form text for 24 hours. After that, you may only send approved template messages.
- **Template messages.** Pre-approved messages with placeholders, for example "Hi {{1}}, your demo is on {{2}}". Meta reviews each template before it can be used.
- **Webhooks.** Meta sends each incoming message to a URL you control. Your automation reads it and replies.

A lead-reply flow

1. A visitor fills the enquiry form on your site. The lead is saved in Supabase.
2. An n8n or Make workflow sends an approved template: "Thanks {{1}}, a counsellor will call you within one working hour."
3. If the customer replies, the webhook receives the message. An AI model (OpenAI or Claude) classifies the intent: price, schedule, complaint, or other.
4. Simple questions get an automatic answer inside the 24-hour window. Anything else goes to a person in the CRM (Chapter 26).

```
// Sending a text reply (Cloud API shape; check the current version in the WhatsApp docs)
POST https://graph.facebook.com/{API_VERSION}/{PHONE_NUMBER_ID}/messages
Authorization: Bearer {ACCESS_TOKEN}
{ "messaging_product": "whatsapp", "to": "9198XXXXXXXX", "type": "text", "text": { "body": "Thanks, we
will call you." } }
```

RULES THAT KEEP YOU OUT OF TROUBLE

Only message people who opted in. Honour "STOP" immediately. Do not send marketing content as a utility template. Keep a record of consent with the date and the source.

Checklist

- Business verified and display name approved.
- Templates approved before launch.
- Webhook verification passes, and each message is saved.
- A human handover path for anything the AI is unsure about.

Reference: the WhatsApp developer documentation (Cloud API), and the Meta Business Suite help pages for account setup. Message limits and pricing change; check the current pricing page before you launch.